

Be a Better Voter

Ballot measures can be complicated to understand; especially the actual impact they will have on your life and society. They change taxes, government programs, voting rules, housing policy, public spending, and other issues that directly affect Californians.

We'll use the CA 2026 Billionaire Tax propositions to see how AI can clarify their impact.

Step 1: Divide the work - 3 minutes

1. Form a group of three.
2. Assign one proposition to each person:
 - **Person 1:** Proposition 40
 - **Person 2:** Proposition 41
 - **Person 3:** Proposition 42

Step 2: Ask AI to Explain Your Proposition — 5 minutes

"Explain California Proposition [40/41/42] in plain English. Tell me (copy and paste the 5 questions as one prompt):

1. What would change if it passes?
2. Who would be directly affected?
3. Where would money come from or go, if relevant?
4. What are the most important real-world consequences?
5. Who is supporting this measure and why?

Keep asking follow-up questions until you feel that you could explain the proposition to someone else. Don't worry yet about whether you support or oppose it.

Step 3: Investigate the Arguments — 5 minutes

Now ask: "What are the strongest arguments made by supporters of this proposition, and what are the strongest arguments made by opponents? Separate factual claims from predictions, assumptions, and value judgments."

Then ask: "Which claims on either side are most important to verify before I decide what I think?" Pick one or two claims that seem especially important.

Step 4: Verify the AI — 5 minutes

Go to the California Secretary of State's Official Voter Information Guide.

<https://www.sos.ca.gov/elections/ballot-measures/qualified-ballot-measures>

Check your AI's explanation against:

- The official title and summary
- The Legislative Analyst's analysis
- The arguments for and against

Look for at least one thing the AI got right and one thing that was incomplete, uncertain, misleading, or worth checking further.

Do not assume the AI is correct just because its answer sounds confident.

Step 5: Teach Your Group — 6 minutes

Take turns explaining, “My proposition does _____.”

Then tell the group:

- What changes if it passes
- Who is most affected
- The strongest argument for it
- The strongest argument against it
- Something important you learned by verifying the AI.

Step 6: Compare the Three Propositions — 5 minutes

Now ask one AI together: “Compare California Propositions 40, 41, and 42. How are they related? Where do they conflict? What could happen if more than one passes?”

Then ask: “Don't tell us how to vote. What are the most important differences and tradeoffs a voter should understand when considering these three measures together?”

Step 7: Discuss

1. What are the key take-aways?
2. Was using the AI useful?